

Marcello's Experience in the Context of Floridian and Caribbean Immigration:

The immigration and assimilation process of those coming to America has been a complicated aspect of American history. Experiences vary widely, even among family members, resulting in several different stories being woven. However, some common threads can be identified, especially when focusing on immigration of certain subgroups, such as the immigrant population in Florida. The Floridian immigrant population includes mainly Caribbean immigrants, specifically those from Cuba and Haiti, with populations representing 23 percent and 8 percent of the Floridian immigrant population, respectively (Gibble 1). These trends still offer an avenue to explore the many nuances of people's individual experiences. Interviews can be leveraged to effectively find trends in these populations. I chose to interview Marcello Santana-Aubert, a first-generation immigrant from Cuba who did not spend that much time in Florida. Marcello's parents moved to the United States in the late 1990s. He was born in California and moved to Oklahoma at a young age, with Cuban relatives also residing in Florida. I find it interesting to relate his individual and familial experiences to the more general academic data that has been detailed through more formal means. I will be focusing on Florida due to the varying waves of immigration that have occurred in the state, and the uniqueness of people's reasoning and level of government assistance. For example, a 1970s Cuban immigrant fleeing political persecution to Florida has a different experience than a 2000s Haitian immigrant fleeing natural disasters. The main similarities I have noticed are the positivity of Cuban immigrants and the reasons behind their decision to move to the United States, specifically Florida. The main differences I have noticed are the support structures present in America and the general

differences between the Cuban and Haitian immigrant populations. I will also examine the chronological waves of Cuban migration and their connection to Marcello's family.

The first similarity that jumped out to me was the positive experience Marcello's family had in the United States. According to a 2017 study on the perceived social mobility and emotional dispositions among South Florida's immigrants, "When compared to Cubans, immigrants from all other origins report higher levels of negative disposition even after controls are considered" (Vaquera and Aranda). Vaquera and Arand note that the majority of those in immigrant populations in South Florida (approximately 56.6%) held a statistically neutral view of the assimilation process in America. However, of those who had a positive experience, respondents indicated a significantly higher positive disposition than the negative disposition of those with a negative experience. To specify, those who had a positive experience reported a very high level of satisfaction (mean of 7.92), while those with a negative experience reported a slightly negative experience (mean of 2.97). Additionally, Cubans represented the most skewed in this trend, with a positive mean of 8.03 and a negative mean of 2.52. This demonstrates that many Cubans maintained a positive attitude toward the United States, which is further corroborated by Marcello's personal experience. He details how his family never really stressed too hard with the problems associated with assimilating, instead focusing on the good. For example, whenever his family faced hardships related to life in the United States, they maintained a sense of gratitude for living in the United States, because, compared to life in Cuba, their hardships seemed relatively minor.

Part of the explanation for why Cubans had an easier time, relatively, transitioning to life in the United States was due to the communist regime under Castro that they were escaping. This communist regime began in the 1960s during the height of the Cold War, in a country 90 miles

away from the United States, the largest opponent of communism at the time. As Logan Padgett states in the article “Why Are People Moving to Florida?,” “People often choose to move to Florida due to its weather, cultural diversity, lower tax rates, large economy, business friendliness, and ability to start small businesses” (Padgett). In the context of specifically Cuban immigrants, this was crucial as they were escaping a regime that made these kinds of economic opportunities nigh impossible for its citizens. Marcello recalled how his grandmother made less than street vendors despite being an eye doctor in Cuba. His grandmother's experience was emblematic of how Cuban immigrants had the incentive to move to America in a context that was much more plagued by economic and political strife than other countries around Florida. Additionally, those leaving Cuba were treated much more favorably by the United States government due to Cold War, anti-communist sentiments. Cuban citizens leaving their country in search of capitalistic opportunities, such as starting businesses, fit the American narrative very well in terms of proving the failures of communism as a system for its citizens. Cuban citizens would also get what they came for, oftentimes creating much more prosperous lives in America than in Cuba.

One of the things that made Marcello's family unique was how the timing of their arrival in America contributed to the support they received in America. Marcello's family would be classified as moving to America during the fourth wave of Cuban migration in the 1990s, as per the PBS article “Cuban Exiles in America.” There are four distinct waves of Cuban migration: the first wave began in the 1950s and went into the early 1960s following Fidel Castro's military takeover of Cuba; the second wave began in the mid 1960s and went into the late 1970s which represented a swell in migration following the implementation of Castro's various communist policies; The third wave started in 1980 and lasted until the late 1980s following an international

incident where a bus crashed into the Peruvian embassy in Cuba, leading to Castro allowing refugee “trash” to leave; the fourth wave began in 1991 and lasted until the late 1990s following the collapse of the Soviet Union and economic support from the USSR to Cuba; What is interesting about Marcello’s family situation is that they had other Cuban relatives whom they could go to for support in America. Due to his family's relatively late arrival in the United States, many other Cuban immigrants had already gone through the migration process, establishing themselves in the United States. Additionally, since they had come during a time of economic downturn in the context of a still anticommunist America, there were resources available to assist with the process of assimilation. Not every immigrant who comes to the United States has a support system in place to assist them, especially if they are undocumented.

The Haitian immigrant population had an immigration experience that was dichotomous from what Marcello’s family faced. To elaborate, this is described by Sage Journals as coming in many forms, with discrimination to Haitian immigrants being based on language, race, ethnicity, and immigrant identity. (Fanfan et al.). Additionally, those who experienced discrimination, as well as those who did not, experienced significant stress in their migration. A quantifiable difference between Marcello’s experience and the average Haitian immigrant’s experience in the United States is the reasoning behind migration. While Cubans historically immigrate in search of better economic opportunities, Haitians have seen spikes in migration due to reasons such as natural disasters. One such example of a natural disaster spiking a Haitian wave of immigration was Hurricane George in 1998. Another aspect to consider is how Marcello describes Cuban culture as focused on improvement rather than worrying about uncontrollable circumstances. Haitian culture is shown in Fanfan’s study to be different, especially in family structure, often having difficulties adjusting to their family they have never met, contrary to the close-knit nature

of Cuban families. What this means is that Cubans often had social safety nets when immigrating to the United States that Haitian immigrants simply did not have. This caused Cuban immigration to be much steadier, as they had time to plan out their migration, while Haitian immigration was much more sporadic, as it usually came from immediate need to immigrate.

(Add paragraph here on how Cuban doctors worked in humanitarian crises, with a focus on the hurricane in Haiti, connecting to similarities/differences, and Marcello's family doctor)

The early 1960s represent the first wave of Cuban migration to the United States. Cubans migrated at such a high rate due to Fidel Castro's takeover of the Cuban government following the Cuban Revolution in 1959. Due to the communist nature of Castro's government, many Cuban citizens were granted asylum in the United States, specifically for political asylum. There was also a great deal of anti-communist rhetoric in the United States, so when citizens of a communist country desired to leave for a capitalist country, the American narrative of pro-capitalism was affirmed. This 1960s American anti-communist rhetoric worked in the Cubans' favor, as it allowed the Cubans to come to America with the American government maintaining that this would help their efforts in the Cold War. Hundreds of thousands of Cubans were resettled throughout the United States

As Miami gained more and more immigrants, a need to relocate them arose. Several hundred thousand Cubans were resettled to different parts of the United States as part of the Cuban Refugee Resettlement Program. This was done through the federal government, but also through many private organizations, like the Catholic Relief Services. These Cuban refugees were often given expedited processes to assimilate into the United States, which included employment and housing for relocation. However, these jobs often came with caveats, with some Cubans being resettled all the way to Alaska, with others being given jobs that were well below

their area of expertise. For example, many University Professors with PhDs were relegated to teaching high school Spanish in the United States. Miami served as the epicenter of the Cuban immigrant population. As Cubans dispersed beyond the city, either voluntarily or through government programs, they began setting up communities in other parts of the country. Consequently, as Cuban communities grew larger, mainland Cubans learned about these communities from friends and family and were inclined to immigrate to those hubs. Marcello's family followed this trend, moving to California rather than Florida in the 1990s due to the preexisting Cuban communities.

The early 1980s represent the third wave of Cuban immigration. This wave included a large population of Cuban males, who were dubbed "Marielitos", being portrayed to the United States public in a less than favorable light. The inherent criminalization of Marielitos was started by Castro and continued into the 1980s American zeitgeist. Castro was quick to call those migrating to America criminals since it helped him politically to state that it was undesirables who were leaving Cuba. These stereotypes were fed into American culture as movies like *Scarface* portrayed these Cubans as gang-affiliated criminals (Jacklin, Refugee 65). While it is true that many of the Cubans who came to America at this time were classified by the Cuban government as criminals, the classifications of criminality often did not fit the American definition of criminality at the time. For example, simply resisting the communist rule could get you classified as a criminal in Cuba, as well as what was called "homosexual activity" (although "sodomy" would not officially be declassified as a crime until the 2003 Supreme Court case *Lawrence v. Texas*). What these various factors led to was a scared public that assumed all Cubans coming to the United States were drug-using, gang-affiliated, criminals. The reality of the situation is most clearly exemplified by how the Carter administration classified this wave of

migrants. Initially, Carter was welcoming of Cuban immigrants, but he began reversing his pleasantries as they classified this wave as seeking economic freedom rather than political freedom. By pivoting away from the traditional political asylum status given to previous generations of Cuban migrants, the Carter administration effectively portrayed this wave less as necessitating asylum, but rather as a group just like any other trying to gain economic gain. This wave of Cuban migrants effectively had to face hardships that their predecessors did not have to face due to the cultural, political, and economic biases of the time.

What differentiated this wave of migration from earlier Cuban waves was its reception in the United States. Over a hundred thousand Cubans, known as the “Marielitos,” were broadly stereotyped as they entered. Marielitos were stereotyped based on their gender, with approximately 70 percent of them being male, as opposed to earlier waves that had a more even gender distribution. This caused Americans to be wary of their gender, as they stereotyped the Cubans arriving as a whole to be coming for nefarious purposes, without concern for what these purposes may be, simply feeding into their fears. One of the more cultural fears relating to the gender ratio was that of the aforementioned homosexuality, with many of the Cubans being charged with homosexual conduct/prostitution in Cuba (Jacklin, Marielitos 31). America was deeply intolerant of non-heterosexual lifestyles, and this led to fears that the Cuban refugees would spread “depraved lifestyles.” Americans’ fears of potential homosexual Cubans were further exacerbated by the AIDS crisis, as gay men were targeted on a national scale. Additionally, racism played a role in these stereotypes, as there was a larger number of Black Cubans arriving in America than in previous waves. Americans were concerned with the race of arriving Cubans, as they were worried about potential gang activity. This was due to local gangs

recruiting newly arrived refugees, as many of the refugees were searching for community and ways to make money.

In conclusion, Marcello's experience helped tell a part of a larger story of immigration centered in Florida and broadened towards the Caribbean. While Marcello's family fits many trends that are backed up by data, studies also show varying degrees of comfort in assimilation, even among individuals who are related. What is important to consider is not just what makes Marcello's story unique, but what can be drawn about the larger story of migration to the United States from his story. Ultimately, it is the relationship between both an individual and a broader experience that needs to be considered in order to tell a full picture and truly understand the complexities of immigration and assimilation in the United States.

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